

defence RUSSIAN AIRCRAFT CARRIER

rier. This new move has incensed defence officials who say it violates the spirit of the inter-governmental agreement between President Putin and the then prime minister Atal Behari Vajpayee in 2004. The *Gorshkov* was one of three strategic arms transfers which included the lease of the three Tu-22M Backfire bombers (since scrapped) and the lease of an Akula-II class nuclear propelled submarine. The navy insists that it will not pay more for the *Gorshkov* and has advised the Government not to renegotiate. "Renegotiating will set a bad precedent for other deals," Mehta says. What has further incensed the navy is that Sevmash has diverted workforce on the carrier from 1,300 to 300 workers. The rest of the workforce is now busy building ballistic missile submarines for the Russian navy.

Russian officials base their new calculation on the premise that not only



The navy plans to operate three carriers in the next decade but being complex warships, they take nearly a decade to build and operationalise. The navy has politely declined an offer to buy the 1961 vintage USS *Kitty Hawk* which is being decommissioned by the US navy this year. It has announced its decision to extend the life of its sole carrier *Viraat* by another decade. The answer could well be in our backyard: the 37,000-tonne Indigenous Aircraft Carrier (IAC), being built at the Cochin Shipyard Ltd. IAC is due to be launched in 2009 and commissioned in around 2014 but the navy plans to speed up the project to induct it as per its original schedule of 2012.

The navy is also alarmed by the delay in 'Project India'—the code name given to the completion and lease of the *Nerpa*, an unfinished Akula-II class nuclear-powered submarine at the Pacific shipyard of Komsomolsk-na-Amure.

"It is a fixed-price contract and Russia must honour it."

ADMIRAL SUREESH MEHTA, CHIEF OF NAVAL STAFF



HIDDEN LEVER?

- Under 'Project India' a Russian nuclear submarine is leased for \$1 billion to train Indian crew.
- Delivery of submarine delayed by six months. There is concern that Russia may use it to extract leverage on *Gorshkov*.

was the deal valued at 2004 dollar prices but the original estimate of \$700 million (Rs 2,800 crore) was three times less than what it should have been. However, they are silent on the prosperity brought into derelict Russian shipyards by the infusion of Indian funds. While defence officials do not admit it, one of the options before India is scrapping the deal. The contract specifies a clause for international arbitration to recover the \$600 million (Rs 2,400 crore) the navy has already paid for the refit. There has been a precedent of a number of recent cases.

"While it will set a bad precedent if we succumb to Russian pressure, we cannot wish away the fact that most of

STEEL SHARK: Transfer of a Russian nuke submarine has been delayed our weapons and equipment and their maintenance stocks are still imported from Russia. Hence, there is a need to take a balanced view of the situation," says Brigadier (retired) Gurmeet Kanwal of the Centre for Land Warfare Studies. The *Gorshkov* is vital because the navy bases its entire strategy around carrier battle groups—a fast moving aircraft carrier escorted by destroyers and frigates, capable of dominating the ocean with their strike aircraft. With the *Viraat* set to retire in the near future, the future of naval carrier-based aviation hangs on the *Gorshkov*.

Construction of the submarine was completed this year but Russia has cited a six-month delay due to machinery problems. While Russia has not made any cost escalation demands on the nuclear submarine which India is leasing for 10 years beginning next year, defence officials say they are preparing for the worst.

The best long-term strategy, say experts, is to continue to diversify our arms import base so as to reduce our heavy dependence on Russian equipment. In the short-term, there is no option but to renegotiate the *Gorshkov* deal on the best terms while holding out the threat of scrapping it if the Russians don't relent.